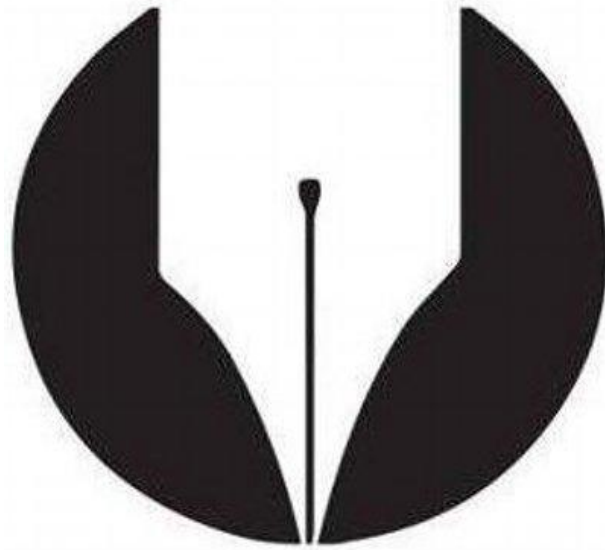




Vox Populi, IIT Kanpur

**Journalism Ethics and
Standards**

AN OPENING NOTE

We, Vox Populi, IIT Kanpur, the Students' Journalism Body of IIT Kanpur, are committed in our resolve to serve the IIT Kanpur community. Working on stories that exist amongst us and need a space to come out, has been our mode of service and we shall continue doing the same.

The first standard by which we would abide when conducting our work is the right of the public to be informed. While the general good of the society and that of every individual therein is something we always intend to protect, we believe that bringing out flaws in a system and giving alternate opinions a proper space is equally important. Public enlightenment is the foundation of the proper functioning of modern societies. In order to ensure the right of the public to be informed, we would strive to the guiding principles, fundamental rights, and duties mentioned in this document. These ethics are the cornerstone of our journalism, and any work outside them shall only hurt our credibility as a body.

Our existence as an independent and free journalism body is of prime importance to us. While we exercise our independence, we do understand our answerability to the Students' Senate and henceforth to the IIT Kanpur community. We will make special attempts to include opinions of the elected body in subjects of higher consequential relevance. We understand that we are not journalists, but a team with the mandate, one granted to us by the Students' Senate, to cover stories journalistically. We appreciate a system of checks through reports and documents and ensure a responsive feedback mechanism but oppose any and every attempt to influence the content we publish by any individual(s)/organization(s).

This document shall henceforth guide us in our service and will be the basis to resolve conflicts with external stakeholders. We will try our best to ensure that all the work we publish shall comply with the standards set forth in this document. Any deviations shall be addressed by us in the best possible manner.

INTRODUCTION

Vox Populi, IIT Kanpur would like to acknowledge their efforts and thank Mr. Harshit Bhalla & Mr. Soumyadeep Datta (Chief Editors, Vox Populi, 2018-19), Editorial Board, Vox Populi, 2018-19, Mr. Anmol Chaman & Mr. Akash Bhardwaj (Chief Editors, Vox Populi, 2019-20), Editorial Board, Vox Populi, 2019-20, Mr. Aditya Sonthalia and Mr. Pulkit Deshmukh for preparing this document.

The Chief Editor(s) of Vox Populi, IIT Kanpur is/are the official spokesperson of the Editorial Board and thereby Vox Populi, IIT Kanpur, and shall be the representative of the body on all official/non-official platforms. They shall be the official chairperson in all meetings of the body.

Vox Populi, IIT Kanpur shall be referred to as Vox henceforth in this document.

SECTION A: FUNDAMENTAL RIGHTS

(A.1) Freedom of expression of the press

A.1.1 Vox reserves the right to publish information or/and opinions from any of its official media.

A.1.2 Vox reserves the right to create a new official platform to publish its content.

A.1.3 Vox reserves the right to work on any subject matter or issue of its choice.

A.1.4 Vox reserves the right to contact any individual(s)/organization(s) for the purpose of its work.

A.1.5 Vox reserves the right to conduct any activity online/offline to collect data or/and insights or/and opinions or/and information for its work.

A.1.6 Vox reserves the right to explore and adopt alternative modes of journalism.

A.1.7 Vox reserves the right to publicize its work/ brand in order to increase its reach.

A.1.8 Right against consequentialism

A.1.8.1 Vox reserves the right to publish a piece of work which highlights a flaw in an organization/established system, lack of an established system, acts of corruption, acts of fraudulent behavior, acts indicating partiality (like nepotism, etc), acts of unprofessional and/or negligent behavior, acts of harassment and all other acts which break the civility of the society without considering the immediate consequences such as loss of trust/ reputation in the general public with that system(s) or/and individual(s) or/and position(s). However, Vox shall provide equal opportunities to the system(s), individual(s) or/and positions(s) to defend themselves in such cases.

(A.2) Right to protect our sources

A.2.1 Vox reserves the right to maintain strict confidentiality about its sources of information regarding any published or unpublished work.

A.2.2 In the event that information about sources is required, a formal request must be made to the Chief Editor(s). The Chief Editor(s) shall thereafter decide whether or not to share the information.

(A.3) Right to refuse work request

A.3.1 The Editorial Board reserves the right to refuse to work on/ publish any piece of work requested by any member of the society.

(A.4) Right of protection against recanted statements

A.4.1 Members of Vox reserve the right to be protected against any consequences in case any statement (that is undistorted or not written out of context) made by a source or official authority published in any of its work is recanted post-publication.

(A.5) Right to safeguard against undue interference

A.5.1 Members of Vox reserve the right to be safeguarded against undue interference by individual(s)/system(s)/organizations(s) for all its work in the ideation, pre-publishing, and post-publishing phase.

A.5.2 Members of Vox reserve the right to not divulge the details of any piece of work which is in the ideation/pre-publishing phase.

(A.6) Copyright over published work

A.6.1 Any piece of work published by Vox cannot be directly reproduced by individual(s)/organizations(s) without the formal consent of the Editorial Board.

A.6.2(a) Any fact/opinion published by Vox cannot be used as a primary source of information or otherwise for any other study or/and investigation without the permission of the Editorial Board.

A.6.2(b) In case a work published by Vox is required by individual(s)/organizations(s) for a study or/and investigation, a formal request regarding the same must be submitted to

the Chief Editor(s). The Editorial Board shall thereupon decide whether or not to give permission.

(A.7) Right to peaceful assembly

A.7.1 All members of Vox reserve a right to assemble in a peaceful manner to carry out discussions on any of its work irrespective of the date and time, unless there is an explicit violation of the rules and regulations of the said meeting place and time.

A.7.2 Members of Vox reserve the right to not divulge the details of the discussion conducted in its meetings to anyone.

A.7.3 Chief Editor(s) of Vox reserve the right to decide the participating members in a Vox meeting.

SECTION B: FUNDAMENTAL DUTIES

(B.1) Maintain the Integrity of work

B.1.1 The Chief Editor(s) and the concerned editor(s) should be free and independent of outside interests and the arrangements of the media with various subjects that might threaten journalistic integrity.

(B.2) Readers should not be misled by the work of Vox Populi

B.2.1 Vox should strive to provide precise and accurate information

B.2.2 Vox should avoid unfounded speculation.

B.2.3 Vox must not deliberately mislead the audience.

B.2.4 Vox must not distort facts and present fabricated materials as true.

(B.3) Source of Information

B.3.1 Vox should only cite first-person information obtained from sources who have first-hand knowledge of the subject matter.

B.3.2 Vox must notify its sources of the nature and context of their involvement.

B.3.3 Vox should cite reports/documents from which information is taken.

B.3.4 While publishing data received from any Survey, Vox should mention the following in the disclaimer or otherwise:

- a. The number of participants.
- b. Mode of data collection.
- c. Method of selection of participants.

B.3.5 Vox should ensure the accuracy of information received from its sources.

B.3.6 Vox should not distort the wording of a quote/ statement which brings it out of the context

(B.4) Language to express the findings

B.4.1 Vox should ensure the civility of language in all of its work to the best of its ability.

B.4.2 Vox should not use language which has the potential to incite or promote discriminatory feelings against any group on the basis of caste, religion, gender, sexual orientation, department, and program of study, C.P.I., hall of residence, etc.

(B.5) Objectivity of Work

B.5.1 Vox must strive to maintain objectivity in its work and ensure that any conclusion drawn in its work should be rooted in facts and reason.

B.5.2 Vox should be honest about acknowledging instants when they have not been able to cover all perspectives of an issue and highlight this as a disclaimer.

B.5.3 Vox should give an equal chance to all members of the society to present their views through opinion pieces.

(B.6) Public Accountability

B.6.1(a) The Editorial Board is answerable to the Students' Senate and other Institute level committees (such as Academic Senate, IAC, ICC, GRC, etc) for content that has been published on any of its official media.

B.6.1(b) However, Vox need not be answerable for any of its work which is in the ideation or processing phase.

B.6.2 The Editorial Board should try to address the concerns of the public for the work published on any of the official media of Vox in order to maintain the credibility of the body. The Editorial Board, however, reserves the right to choose the channel of interaction with the public.

B.6.3 In the event of an error (a violation of any particular clause of this document) that has been established in its work, Vox should issue a public apology or/and corrigendum through the platform used for publishing.

SECTION C: DEFINITIONS AND WORK CATEGORISATION

Opinion Piece

An opinion piece is a narrative essay that presents the writer's opinion or thoughts about a particular issue. Opinion pieces can raise awareness about a particular topic or aim to persuade others and can substantiate the writer as an expert on a subject. The writer of the opinion piece is the only owner of any and every opinion of the story.

Editorial

An essay by the editor(s) instating their assertions on a subject matter of their choice. This aim is to present the opinion of the editor(s) on a multipolar subject or to highlight details that could concern the general public.

Investigation

An article or a group of articles pertaining to an issue that concerns the general public or its section, which involves unraveling of facts or/and reporting of events or/and interviews related to the subject.

Data Journalism

A quantitative analysis of a subject matter based on data collected either through online/offline surveys, publicly available information, or/and collaborative work with external individual(s)/organization(s).

Non-investigative Interviews

Interviews of guests, students, alums, faculty, etc. that do not involve a pre-intended target issue and are not tied to any Editorials, Op-Eds, or/and Investigations.

Community Writings

A piece of work pertaining to stories, experiences, or/and anecdotes related to the life of an individual(s). The mandate for this type of works should be floating. The aim could be to cover relevant social issues like Mental Health, Sexism, Casteism, etc.

Satire

Use of humor, irony, exaggeration, or ridicule to expose and criticize a fact, event, opinion or/and arguments on a particular issue. The objective is to use sarcasm to draw attention to a particular subject matter concerning society.

Please note that this is not an exhaustive list. This is an informative section the objective of which is to ensure that the community is notified about operational standards and expectations from a particular piece of work.

Under clause A.1.6 of this document, Vox reserves the right to explore new modes to publish its work. The above list can be expanded as and when required based on the independent discretion of the Editorial Board.

APPENDIX A: PROVISION TO MAKE AN AMENDMENT

AA.1 An appeal to bring an amendment can only be made by the Chief Editor(s). However, the Student's Senate can suggest an amendment to the Chief Editor(s).

AA.2 The amendment can only be made in a regular/special meeting of Students' Senate and must be proposed in the form of an agenda item. The agenda item must be shared with the general body members at least 24 hrs prior to the meeting.

AA.3 In case the amendment aims to add standards/ethics in a dimension that has not been covered in this document, then more than a one-half majority is required.

AA.4 In case the amendment aims to change the existing standards/ ethics, or influence the existing standards/ethics then more than a two-thirds majority is required.

APPENDIX B: SPECIAL INVITEE IN MEETINGS

AB.1 Under Section A.7.3, the Chief Editor(s) reserve the right to decide the participating members of a meeting. However, for subjects where the Editorial Board believes that an alternate perspective or/and opinions from elected representatives are necessary, the Editorial Board meetings may have a Students' Senate nominee as a special invitee.

AB.2 In case a Students' Senate nominee is needed, a call regarding the same will be made to the Chairperson, Students' Senate. The call must explicitly state the date, time, venue, and the agenda(s) concerning the Students' Senate and shall be made 24 hours before the meeting. However, for emergency meetings, a shorter notice period of 4 hours shall be required.

AB.3 The appointed nominee:

- I. Shall not be in direct conflict with the concerned agenda(s).
- II. Shall only be present as a non-voting member.
- III. Shall only present his views on agenda(s) notified to the Chairperson, Students' Senate.
- IV. Shall respect the confidentiality of our sources and ongoing work.

AB.4 Article A.5 of this document gives us the right to maintain confidentiality in our work. Therefore, any details about the sources of information, the pre-publishing ideation, and the modus operandi shall not be divulged to the nominee.

AB.5 The Chairperson, Students' Senate must notify the Chief Editor(s) about the appointed nominee at least 4 hours in advance of the meeting.

AB.6 The Chief Editor(s) should ensure the appointed nominee is not in direct conflict with any agenda(s) being discussed. They may choose to disallow a particular individual on the ground of a conflict with any of the agenda(s) of the meeting. The Chairperson, Students' Senate in this case must send a different nominee to the meeting.

AB.7 If the Editorial Board opines that the nominee interferes with agenda(s) other than those notified to the Chairperson, Students' Senate or/and disrupts the peace and decorum of the meeting in any way, the Chief Editor(s) shall notify the same to the

Chairperson, Student's Senate. The concerned individual shall then be disallowed for the meetings in the future.